

NEW KID ON THE BALL

Sunil Chhetri leads a talented young crop of players who give Indian football a reason to hope

Just two days before the Independence Day, India won something it hadn't in 24 years. For the first time after 1984, the national football team secured a berth in the Asian Cup, the continent's loftiest tournament, after emerging winners in the AFC Challenge Cup. The man who nailed it was a diminutive forward. In the final match at the Ambedkar Stadium in Delhi, on three occasions Sunil Chhetri shrugged off the tall markers that formed the Tajikistan defence line and darted in to hit the goal. With a bonus goal from captain Bhaichung Bhutia, India not only won 4-1, its most comprehensive victory in recent years, but for the second time ever, clinched a berth in the Asian Cup to be held in Qatar in 2011.

Chhetri can't really be called Bhutia redux, although their styles are quite similar. In an era when football is all about tall and muscular men who use their height and strength to keep opponents at bay, these two with their short height and thin frames have used their builds advantageously to sail past intimidating large defenders. The 24-year-old's exploits during the AFC Challenge and Nehru Cup last year—which also India won—have invited comparisons with the Indian captain, though at his age, Bhutia showed more promise. But while Chhetri feels no one among the next-generation players can be a substitute to Bhutia, optimism surrounds him. "The Asian Cup is three years away and by that time we'll have 20 boys who can be the next Bhutia," says Chhetri. Perhaps he's to football what M.S. Dhoni is to cricket, the youngster who brings value to his sport in terms of young energy. He belongs to that era of Indian football which has just begun



Chhetri is to football what Dhoni is to cricket; the youngster brings value to his sport in terms of raw energy.

to turn around. "I'm just enjoying the gig right now," he says.

Bhutia will be 32 later this year and it is not known if he will continue to play until the 2011 Asian Cup. If he doesn't, we know who the backup is. Last season, Chhetri's 12 goals got him the NFL player of the year and best forward awards. Apart from teamwork, one thing that Chhetri largely credits for Indian football's two international wins in the last couple of years, is the training by Coach Bob Houghton. "He has single-handedly changed the scenario," says Chhetri. Houghton, who has been coaching the Indian team for the last two years, has 33 years of experience in the business and was once the youngest-ever football

coach in England. "He is solely responsible for changing our game psychology, and has made us feel we can win," says Chhetri.

Even eight years ago, the boy who joined football for a lark wouldn't be seen mouthing such serious quotes. As an army-dad's son leading a comfortable urban existence, football was something he started playing for certificates at the school level. At the Army Public School in Delhi, he took to playing the game when he was noticed by the Mohun Bagan Club which asked him to come for trials.

It was only in the last three years or so, when Chhetri realised how much glory the game can bring him, that he started taking the game seriously. His mentor and coach at JCT, Sukhwinder Singh, has been responsible for this to quite an extent and the results are showing. This season, he has moved back to Kolkata where he will don the red and gold of East Bengal. Back in Kolkata after his win, Chhetri feels he needs to

find his feet in the city's highly competitive club circuit, but the young footballer also wants to complete his graduation because his father insists.

But nothing is more important to Chhetri than playing football, especially if it is for his country. His best birthday present when he turned 24 this month, he says, was the AFC quarter final win over Turkmenistan. It didn't matter that his eye was badly bruised after a particularly vicious tackle from an opposing defender. He recovered well in time to score the winner in the semi-finals and the first-ever hatrick by an Indian in an international football final. Indian football has begun to live in hope again.

by Swagata Sen